TCW 1103 · ENGINEERING COMMUNICATION SKILLS · PART 1

Letters and Workplace Documents: Notes and Model Examples

Every letter and document type you can be asked to write, each with notes (purpose, structure, tone, useful phrases) and a complete worked example in the fully blocked, open-punctuation layout. Use it as the exam-room template book.

WHITEPAPER 4 · COMPANION

COURSE
TCW 1103 Engineering Communication Skills (Part 1)

DEPARTMENT
Civil & Water Engineering, NUST Faculty of Engineering

LECTURER
Mr T. L. Luzane

PREPARED FOR
Group 13 · exam on Monday 26 October 2026

INSIDE: 22 MODEL DOCUMENTS

1. Letter layout, parts and rules
2. Tone and the phrase bank
3. Letter of enquiry
4. Reply to an enquiry (quotation)
5. Order letter
6. Letter of complaint
7. Adjustment letter (granting a complaint)
8. Refusal letter (bad news)
9. Job application letter
10. Motivation letter (scholarship)
11. Request for industrial attachment
12. Curriculum vitae
13. Accepting and declining a job offer
14. Letter of appointment (offer)
15. Resignation letter
16. Apology, thanks and invitation letters
17. Letter to the editor
18. Circular letter
19. Informal (personal) letter
20. Memo, formal email and public notice
21. Notice of meeting with agenda; press release
22. Exam drill: 15 letter questions

All names, companies, addresses and numbers in the examples are invented for practice, except the NUST postal address. Change the details to fit the question.

Group 13
Study Board

1 Letter layout, parts and rules

A **business (formal) letter** is a written message sent **outside** an organisation, or to a person in their official capacity. It is a permanent, legal record, so layout, tone and accuracy carry marks. Zimbabwean universities teach the **fully blocked layout with open punctuation**: every line starts at the left margin, paragraphs are not indented, one blank line separates the parts, and there is no punctuation at the ends of address lines, the date, the salutation or the complimentary close.

#	Part (in order)
1	**Sender's address** (or printed letterhead). In a personal formal letter, your address without your name.
2	**References**: Our ref: / Your ref: (business letters)
3	**Date** in full: 24 October 2026
4	**Inside address**: title or designation, organisation, address
5	**Attention line** (optional): For the attention of Mr P Dube
6	**Salutation**
7	**Subject heading** in capitals or bold
8	**Body**: opening, middle, closing paragraphs
9	**Complimentary close**
10	**Signature**, typed **name**, **designation**
11	**Enc:** (enclosures) and **cc:** (copies)

Salutation and close must match

Salutation	Close
Dear Sir or Madam / Dear Sir / Dear Madam	**Yours faithfully**
Dear Mr Moyo / Dear Dr Ncube / Dear Eng. Dube	**Yours sincerely**
Dear Tendai (informal, friend)	Yours / Best wishes / Your friend

Golden rules

- Capital "Y" only: "Yours faithfully", never "Yours Faithfully".
- No comma after the salutation or close in open punctuation.
- Subject heading tells the reader the topic in under ten words; "RE:" is optional.
- First paragraph: why you are writing. Last paragraph: what you want to happen next.
- Do not use contractions (don't, I'm) or slang in formal letters.
- One page where possible; check names, dates and figures.
- **Direct order** for good or routine news (main point first); **indirect order** for bad news and persuasion (buffer, reasons, news, goodwill close).

HOW LETTER QUESTIONS ARE MARKED (TYPICAL 20-MARK SCHEME)

Layout and format (addresses, date, salutation, heading, close, name, designation): about 6. **Content** (all the points the question asks for, relevant details invented sensibly): about 8. **Language and tone** (formal, polite, correct grammar, matches the purpose): about 4. **Organisation** (logical paragraphs, clear opening and close): about 2. Losing layout marks is the easiest way to drop a grade.

2 Tone and the phrase bank

Business letters should be **formal but natural**: short sentences, active voice, the "you-attitude" (write from the reader's point of view) and courtesy even when complaining. Avoid outdated phrases such as "We are in receipt of your esteemed letter" or "Please find attached herewith".

Purpose	Useful phrases
Opening	I am writing to enquire about… / With reference to your advertisement in *The Chronicle* of 20 October 2026, … / Thank you for your letter of 12 October 2026 regarding… / Further to our telephone conversation this morning, …
Requesting	I would be grateful if you could… / Could you please send me… / Kindly advise whether…
Complaining	I am writing to express my dissatisfaction with… / Unfortunately, the goods did not… / I would expect a replacement by…
Apologising	Please accept our sincere apologies for… / We regret any inconvenience this has caused.
Giving bad news	After careful consideration, we are unable to… / Unfortunately, on this occasion…
Enclosing	I enclose a copy of… / Please find enclosed… / Attached is… (email)
Closing	I look forward to hearing from you. / Please do not hesitate to contact me on… if you need further information. / Thank you for your prompt attention to this matter.

3 Letter of enquiry

Purpose: to ask for information about products, services, prices, courses or availability. It is a **routine request**, so use direct order. **Structure**: (1) who you are and what you are enquiring about; (2) the specific questions, numbered if several; (3) any deadline and why; (4) polite close.

EXAMPLE 1 · LETTER OF ENQUIRY

Department of Civil and Water Engineering
National University of Science and Technology
PO Box AC 939
Ascot
Bulawayo

24 October 2026

The Sales Manager
Matopos Surveying Equipment (Pvt) Ltd
22 Jason Moyo Street
Bulawayo

Dear Sir or Madam

ENQUIRY ABOUT THE HIRE OF DUMPY LEVELS AND TOTAL STATIONS

I am writing on behalf of the Part 1 Civil and Water Engineering class at NUST to enquire about hiring surveying equipment for a field practical in November 2026.

We would be grateful if you could provide the following information:

1. the daily and weekly hire rates for dumpy levels with tripods and staffs
2. whether total stations are available for hire, and at what rate
3. whether you deliver to the NUST campus, and the delivery charge
4. any deposit or insurance requirements.

We expect to need six dumpy levels and two total stations from 9 to 13 November 2026. As our department must approve the budget by 30 October 2026, we would appreciate your reply before that date.

I look forward to hearing from you.

Yours faithfully

[signature]
T R Ndlovu
Class Representative

4 Reply to an enquiry (quotation)

Purpose: to answer every question in the enquiry and persuade the reader to buy. **Structure**: (1) thank them and refer to their letter by date; (2) answer each question in the same order, with exact prices and terms; (3) add a selling point; (4) say how to place the order; invite contact.

EXAMPLE 2 · REPLY TO AN ENQUIRY

Matopos Surveying Equipment (Pvt) Ltd
22 Jason Moyo Street
Bulawayo

Our ref: MSE/Q/1182
Your ref: CWE/P1/26

27 October 2026

Mr T R Ndlovu
Class Representative
Department of Civil and Water Engineering
National University of Science and Technology
PO Box AC 939
Ascot
Bulawayo

Dear Mr Ndlovu

QUOTATION FOR THE HIRE OF SURVEYING EQUIPMENT

Thank you for your letter of 24 October 2026 enquiring about the hire of surveying equipment for your field practical. We are pleased to quote as follows:

1. Dumpy level with tripod and 5 m staff: US$12 per day or US$50 per week per set.
2. Total station with prism and pole: US$45 per day or US$180 per week per set.
3. Delivery and collection at NUST: free for orders above US$300.
4. A refundable deposit of 20% is required; all equipment is insured by us.

For six dumpy levels and two total stations for one week, the total hire is US$660, with free delivery. All instruments were calibrated in September 2026 and certificates are available on request.

To confirm the booking, please send an official order by 2 November 2026. Should you need any further information, please contact me on 0292 000 111.

Yours sincerely

[signature]
N Sibanda (Mrs)
Sales Manager

5 Order letter

Purpose: to place a definite order. It becomes part of a contract, so it must be **exact**: item, code, quantity, unit price, total, delivery date and place, payment method. Usually accompanied by an official order form.

EXAMPLE 3 · ORDER LETTER

[NUST address as in Example 1]

30 October 2026

The Sales Manager
Matopos Surveying Equipment (Pvt) Ltd

22 Jason Moyo Street
Bulawayo

Dear Mrs Sibanda

ORDER NO. CWE/0457: HIRE OF SURVEYING EQUIPMENT

Thank you for your quotation MSE/Q/1182 of 27 October 2026. We are pleased to place the following order:

Item	Qty	Rate	Period	Amount
Dumpy level, tripod and staff	6	US$50/week	1 week	US$300
Total station, prism and pole	2	US$180/week	1 week	US$360
Total				**US$660**

Please deliver the equipment to the Surveying Laboratory, Block C, NUST, by 08:00 on Monday 9 November 2026, and collect it on Friday 13 November 2026 at 16:00. The 20% deposit of US$132 will be paid by bank transfer on confirmation, and the balance on return of the equipment.

Kindly confirm acceptance of this order in writing.

Yours sincerely

[signature]
Dr B Moyo
Chairperson, Department of Civil and Water Engineering

Enc: Official order form CWE/0457

6 Letter of complaint

Purpose: to report a problem and obtain a remedy. **Tone**: firm, factual, courteous; never insulting. **Structure** (the "five Fs"): **Facts** of the transaction (date, invoice, order) → **Fault** in detail with evidence → **Feelings/effect** on you → **Fix** you want, with a deadline → **Finish** politely.

EXAMPLE 4 · LETTER OF COMPLAINT (POOR SERVICE)

14 Hillside Road
Hillside
Bulawayo

24 October 2026

The Area Manager
Bulawayo City Council Water Department
City Hall
Fife Street
Bulawayo

Dear Sir or Madam

BURST WATER MAIN ON HILLSIDE ROAD: REPORT NO. W/7781

I am writing to complain about the delay in repairing a burst water main outside 14 Hillside Road, first reported to your office on 6 October 2026 under report number W/7781.

Clean water has been flowing down the road for eighteen days. The road shoulder is now eroded to a depth of about 300 mm, the pavement is becoming unsafe for pedestrians and residents of the area have had low water pressure every evening. I telephoned your office again on 13 and 20 October and was told each time that a team would come "soon".

Apart from the inconvenience to residents, the loss of treated water at a time of water rationing is a serious waste of public resources.

I therefore request that the main be repaired and the road shoulder reinstated by Friday 30 October 2026. I would be grateful for written confirmation of the repair date.

Thank you for your attention to this urgent matter.

Yours faithfully

[signature]
Rudo Ncube (Ms)

Enc: photographs of the site (3)
cc: Ward 5 Councillor

7 Adjustment letter (granting a complaint)

Purpose: to reply positively to a complaint and keep the customer's goodwill. Good news goes first (direct order). **Structure**: (1) thank, apologise and state the remedy at once; (2) explain briefly what went wrong (no excuses, no blaming staff); (3) say what you are doing to prevent it recurring; (4) goodwill close.

EXAMPLE 5 · ADJUSTMENT LETTER

Ascot Building Supplies
14 Fort Street
Bulawayo

Our ref: CS/2210

26 October 2026

Mr R Sibanda
Laboratory Technician
Department of Civil and Water Engineering
National University of Science and Technology
PO Box AC 939
Ascot
Bulawayo

Dear Mr Sibanda

REPLACEMENT OF CEMENT: INVOICE NO. 4471

Thank you for your letter of 22 October 2026. We are sorry that 18 of the 60 bags of cement delivered to your laboratory were unusable, and we will deliver 18 replacement bags free of charge on Wednesday 28 October 2026. Our driver will collect the damaged bags at the same time.

Our investigation shows that the bags were stored near a leaking roof section of our warehouse before dispatch. The roof has now been repaired, and all cement is now checked for lumps before loading.

As an apology for the delay to your students' cube tests, we have also credited your account with 10% of the value of the original order.

We value our long relationship with NUST and look forward to serving you again.

Yours sincerely

[signature]
G Chikore
Customer Service Manager

8 Refusal letter (bad news)

Purpose: to say no while keeping goodwill. Use the **indirect order**: (1) **buffer**: a neutral, positive opening (thanks, agreement); (2) **reasons** before the refusal, so the reader understands; (3) the **bad news** stated

clearly but briefly, not in the first or last sentence; (4) an **alternative** if possible; (5) a forward-looking, friendly **close**. Never apologise excessively or blame the reader.

EXAMPLE 6 · REFUSAL OF A REQUEST

Gwayi Consulting Engineers
5 Leopold Takawira Avenue
Bulawayo

28 October 2026

Ms S Chiworeso
Department of Civil and Water Engineering
National University of Science and Technology
PO Box AC 939
Ascot
Bulawayo

Dear Ms Chiworeso

YOUR REQUEST FOR A SITE VISIT TO THE MZINGWANE PIPELINE PROJECT

Thank you for your letter of 20 October 2026. We are pleased that your class is interested in our water projects, and we share your view that site visits are valuable for young engineers.

The Mzingwane pipeline is currently at the trenching and pipe-laying stage, with deep excavations and heavy plant working along the whole route. Our insurers and the client's safety rules allow only inducted staff on site during this phase. For these reasons, we are unable to host your class in November.

However, the pumping station will be commissioned in February 2027, and we would be glad to arrange a guided visit then. Our resident engineer could also give a one-hour talk on the project at NUST in November if that would be useful.

Please contact me on 0292 000 222 to arrange either option. We wish your class every success in your examinations.

Yours sincerely

[signature]
Eng. P Dube
Projects Director

9 Job application letter

Purpose: to apply for an advertised (solicited) or unadvertised (unsolicited) post and win an interview. It is a sales letter where the product is you. **Structure**: (1) the post, reference and where advertised; (2) qualifications matched to the requirements; (3) experience and skills with evidence; (4) why this company; (5) availability, request for interview, enclosures.

EXAMPLE 7 · APPLICATION FOR AN ADVERTISED POST

House 1189 Mkoba 6
Gweru

24 October 2026

The Human Resources Manager
Zambezi Roads and Bridges (Pvt) Ltd
PO Box 4400
Harare

Dear Sir or Madam

APPLICATION FOR THE POST OF GRADUATE CIVIL ENGINEER (REF: ZRB/GE/09)

I wish to apply for the post of Graduate Civil Engineer advertised in *The Herald* of 20 October 2026. I have recently completed a Bachelor of Engineering (Honours) degree in Civil and Water Engineering at the National University of Science and Technology, where I obtained an upper second class pass.

Your advertisement asks for knowledge of road design and the ability to use design software. My final-year project was the geometric design of a 3.2 km rural access road in Gweru District, for which I used AutoCAD Civil 3D to produce the alignment, longitudinal sections and earthworks quantities. I also completed modules in highway engineering, soil mechanics and structural design.

During my twelve-month industrial attachment with the Ministry of Transport in Bulawayo, I supervised a gravel resealing crew of eight, carried out compaction tests and prepared weekly progress reports. This taught me to communicate clearly with both technical staff and labourers and to work to tight deadlines.

I am particularly interested in your company because of your work on the rehabilitation of the Harare–Masvingo highway, and I would welcome the opportunity to contribute to projects of that scale.

I enclose my curriculum vitae and certified copies of my certificates. I am available for an interview at any time and can be reached on 0771 000 333 or tk.example@email.com.

Yours faithfully

[signature]
Tafadzwa Moyo

Enc: Curriculum vitae; certificates (3)

10 Motivation letter (scholarship or programme)

Purpose: to persuade a selection panel that you deserve a place or scholarship. It is more personal than a job letter: **motivation, goals and fit**. **Structure**: (1) what you are applying for; (2) your background and what drives your interest (a short, true story); (3) achievements and evidence; (4) goals and how the programme helps you reach them; (5) what you will give back; (6) close.

EXAMPLE 8 · MOTIVATION LETTER

[NUST address as in Example 1]

24 October 2026

The Selection Committee
Southern Africa Water Engineering Scholarship Fund
PO Box 1550
Harare

Dear Members of the Committee

MOTIVATION LETTER: 2027 WATER ENGINEERING SCHOLARSHIP

I am applying for the 2027 Water Engineering Scholarship to support my studies towards the Bachelor of Engineering (Honours) degree in Civil and Water Engineering at NUST, where I am in my first year.

My interest in water engineering began in Gutu, where I grew up watching women in my village walk four kilometres a day to the nearest borehole during the dry season. When a community project installed a solar-powered pump and storage tank in 2021, I saw how one well-designed system could give hours back to every family. I decided then that I wanted to design such systems.

I obtained 15 points at A Level in Mathematics, Physics and Chemistry, and I am currently among the top ten students in my class. I am a member of the NUST Engineering Society, and I helped organise a clean-water awareness day at a primary school in Bulawayo in September 2026.

After graduating, I intend to specialise in rural water supply and to register as a professional engineer with the Engineering Council of Zimbabwe. Your scholarship would allow me to concentrate fully on my studies instead of part-time work, and your mentorship programme would connect me with practising water engineers.

In return, I commit to volunteering in your community water projects during vacations and to sharing what I learn with younger students.

Thank you for considering my application. I would welcome the opportunity of an interview.

Yours faithfully

[signature]
Tinashe Ndlovu
Student Number: N0XXXXXXX

Use "Yours faithfully" with "Dear Members of the Committee" because no individual is named.

11 Request for industrial attachment

An **unsolicited application**: nothing has been advertised, so you must explain the attachment requirement, what you can do and what you are asking for (dates, duration).

EXAMPLE 9 · ATTACHMENT REQUEST

[NUST address as in Example 1]

24 October 2026

The Resident Engineer
Zimbabwe National Water Authority
Matabeleland South Catchment
PO Box 2010
Bulawayo

Dear Sir or Madam

REQUEST FOR INDUSTRIAL ATTACHMENT: AUGUST 2027 TO JULY 2028

I am a Civil and Water Engineering student at the National University of Science and Technology, and I am writing to request a place for industrial attachment with your catchment office. My degree programme requires twelve months of supervised work experience, from August 2027 to July 2028.

By then I will have completed courses in hydraulics, surveying, engineering drawing, soil mechanics and hydrology. I am competent in AutoCAD and Microsoft Excel, and I have experience with levelling and chain surveying from our field practicals.

I am keen to gain experience in dam safety monitoring, flow gauging and water supply operations, which are central to ZINWA's work. I am hard-working, punctual and willing to work on remote sites.

I enclose my curriculum vitae, academic transcript and a letter from the Department confirming the attachment requirement. I would be grateful for an opportunity to discuss my application with you.

Yours faithfully

[signature]
Shannel Chiworeso

Enc: CV; transcript; departmental letter

12 Curriculum vitae

The CV is a summary of your education, skills and experience. **Rules**: 1–2 pages; most recent first (reverse chronological); headings; bullet points with action verbs (designed, supervised, prepared); honest; no photo, ID number, religion or marital status unless asked; referees with permission.

EXAMPLE 10 · STUDENT CV

TINASHE R NDLOVU

House 22, Ascot, Bulawayo · 0771 000 444 · tk.example@email.com · linkedin.com/in/example

PROFILE
First-year Civil and Water Engineering student with strong mathematics and AutoCAD skills and experience leading student teams. Seeking vacation work in water supply or construction.

EDUCATION
2026 – present: BEng (Hons) Civil and Water Engineering, National University of Science and Technology, Bulawayo
2023 – 2024: ZIMSEC A Level: Mathematics (A), Physics (A), Chemistry (B), Mkoba High School, Gweru
2019 – 2022: ZIMSEC O Level: 9 subjects including Mathematics and English (A), Mkoba High School

SKILLS
Technical: AutoCAD 2D, Microsoft Excel (formulas, charts), basic Python, levelling with a dumpy level
Communication: report writing, presentations, minute taking
Languages: English, Shona, Ndebele (conversational)

EXPERIENCE AND PROJECTS
Dec 2025 – Jan 2026: Assistant, Gweru Builders (vacation work): measured and recorded materials deliveries; assisted with setting out a 3-bedroom house.
2026: Class revision website: designed and maintain a study website used by classmates.

ACHIEVEMENTS AND LEADERSHIP
Class representative (2026) · Prize for Best A Level Mathematics Student, Mkoba High School (2024)

INTERESTS
Robotics, chess, community clean-water projects

REFEREES
Mr T L Luzane, Lecturer, Department of Civil and Water Engineering, NUST · 0292 000 555
Mrs A Chari, Head of Science, Mkoba High School, Gweru · 0392 000 666

13 Accepting and declining a job offer

EXAMPLE 11 · ACCEPTANCE

[Your address]

2 November 2026

Mrs F Gumbo
Human Resources Manager
Zambezi Roads and Bridges (Pvt) Ltd
PO Box 4400
Harare

Dear Mrs Gumbo

ACCEPTANCE OF THE POST OF GRADUATE CIVIL ENGINEER

Thank you for your letter of 29 October 2026 offering me the post of Graduate Civil Engineer. I am delighted to accept the offer on the terms stated, including the monthly salary and the six-month probation period.

As agreed, I will report to your Harare office at 08:00 on Monday 1 December 2026. I enclose the signed contract and the medical certificate you requested.

I look forward to joining your team.

EXAMPLE 12 · DECLINING

[Your address]

2 November 2026

Mr K Banda
Managing Director
Gwayi Consulting Engineers
5 Leopold Takawira Avenue
Bulawayo

Dear Mr Banda

OFFER OF THE POST OF ASSISTANT ENGINEER

Thank you for offering me the post of Assistant Engineer and for the time you and your panel spent with me during the interview.

After careful thought, I have decided to accept a position in road design, which is closer to the area I studied for my final-year project. I must therefore decline your offer with regret.

I was impressed by your firm's water projects, and I hope that our paths will cross again in future.

Yours sincerely

Yours sincerely

[signature]
Tafadzwa Moyo

Enc: signed contract; medical certificate

[signature]
Tafadzwa Moyo

14 Letter of appointment (offer of employment)

Written by the employer. Must state: the post, start date, salary and benefits, probation, hours, place of work, reporting line, conditions of the offer and how to accept by a deadline.

EXAMPLE 13 · LETTER OF APPOINTMENT

Zambezi Roads and Bridges (Pvt) Ltd
PO Box 4400
Harare

Our ref: HR/APP/26/031

29 October 2026

Mr Tafadzwa Moyo
House 1189 Mkoba 6
Gweru

Dear Mr Moyo

OFFER OF APPOINTMENT: GRADUATE CIVIL ENGINEER

Following your interview on 26 October 2026, we are pleased to offer you the post of Graduate Civil Engineer in our Roads Division, on the following terms:

1. Start date: Monday 1 December 2026, at our Harare office.
2. Salary: as set out in the attached schedule, paid monthly, plus medical aid and a site allowance when working away from Harare.
3. Probation: six months, after which your appointment will be confirmed subject to satisfactory performance.
4. Hours: 07:30 to 16:30, Monday to Friday.
5. Reporting to: the Senior Resident Engineer, Roads Division.
6. Conditions: the offer is subject to a satisfactory medical examination and verification of your qualifications.

Please confirm your acceptance by signing and returning the enclosed contract by 6 November 2026.

We look forward to welcoming you to the company.

Yours sincerely

[signature]
F Gumbo (Mrs)
Human Resources Manager

Enc: contract of employment (2 copies); salary schedule

15 Resignation letter

Purpose: formal notice of leaving. Keep it **short, positive and professional**: state the resignation and last working day (respecting the notice period in your contract), thank the employer, offer to help with handover. Never use it to complain.

EXAMPLE 14 · RESIGNATION

[Your address]

24 October 2026

The Senior Resident Engineer
Roads Division
Zambezi Roads and Bridges (Pvt) Ltd
PO Box 4400
Harare

Dear Eng. Mutasa

RESIGNATION

Please accept this letter as formal notice of my resignation from the post of Civil Engineer. In accordance with my contract, which requires one month's notice, my last working day will be Tuesday 24 November 2026.

I have accepted a post that will allow me to specialise in water supply engineering. I am grateful for the support and training I have received during my three years with the company, especially on the Harare–Masvingo highway project.

I will make sure that my files, drawings and site records are up to date and will help to brief my successor before I leave.

Yours sincerely

[signature]
Tafadzwa Moyo
Civil Engineer

16 Apology, thanks and invitation letters

EXAMPLE 15 · LETTER OF APOLOGY

[Company address]

24 October 2026

Mr S Ndlovu
Headmaster
Mzilikazi High School
PO Box 300
Bulawayo

Dear Mr Ndlovu

MISSED CAREERS DAY PRESENTATION

Please accept my sincere apologies for failing to attend your Careers Day on 22 October 2026, where I had agreed to speak to your Form 6 students about engineering.

On the morning of the event, a retaining wall on one of our sites showed signs of failure and I was required to remain on site until it was made safe. I should have telephoned your office earlier, and I regret that your students were kept waiting.

I would be glad to visit the school on any date before the end of term that suits you, and I will bring two of our graduate engineers with me.

Yours sincerely

EXAMPLE 16 · LETTER OF THANKS

[NUST address]

24 October 2026

Eng. P Dube
Projects Director
Gwayi Consulting Engineers
5 Leopold Takawira Avenue
Bulawayo

Dear Eng. Dube

THANK YOU FOR THE GUEST LECTURE

On behalf of the Part 1 Civil and Water Engineering class, I would like to thank you for the lecture you gave on 21 October 2026 on the Mzingwane pipeline.

Your explanation of how pipe sizes were chosen, and the photographs of thrust blocks and air valves, made our hydraulics lectures much clearer. Many students have said that it was the most useful session of the semester.

We look forward to visiting the pumping station in February.

Yours sincerely

[signature]
T R Ndlovu
Class Representative

[signature]
Eng. R Mpofu
Projects Manager

EXAMPLE 17 · LETTER OF INVITATION

NUST Engineering Society
Faculty of Engineering
National University of Science and Technology
PO Box AC 939
Ascot
Bulawayo

24 October 2026

Eng. M Khumalo
President
Zimbabwe Institution of Engineers
PO Box 660
Harare

Dear Eng. Khumalo

INVITATION TO BE GUEST SPEAKER AT THE ENGINEERING SOCIETY DINNER

The NUST Engineering Society has great pleasure in inviting you to be our guest speaker at our annual dinner on Friday 20 November 2026 at 18:30 in the NUST Great Hall.

About 250 students and staff will attend. We would be honoured if you could speak for about twenty minutes on "The young engineer in Zimbabwe's infrastructure future". The society will cover your travel and accommodation in Bulawayo.

We would be grateful if you could let us know by 6 November 2026 whether you are able to accept. Please contact me on 0771 000 777 for any further details.

Yours sincerely

[signature]
Miss T Macheke
Secretary, NUST Engineering Society

Reply to an invitation: accept or decline in the first sentence, repeat the date, time and place (acceptance) or give a brief reason and good wishes (declining).

17 Letter to the editor

Purpose: to express a public opinion in a newspaper. Addressed to "The Editor", salutation "Dear Sir" or "Dear Editor", close "Yours faithfully". Give a headline-style subject, state your view early, support it with facts, propose a solution, and sign with your name and town (or a pen name if allowed). Keep it short and civil.

EXAMPLE 18 · LETTER TO THE EDITOR

12 Selborne Avenue
Bulawayo

24 October 2026

The Editor
The Chronicle

PO Box 585
Bulawayo

Dear Editor

BLOCKED STORM DRAINS WILL FLOOD THE CITY AGAIN

With the rainy season only weeks away, I wish to draw attention to the state of the storm water drains in the city centre.

A walk along Fife Street and Lobengula Street shows drains filled with sand, plastic bottles and litter. Last January, the same drains overflowed after one heavy storm, flooding shops and damaging vehicles. Engineers know that a drain that is half full of silt carries less than half its design flow.

I urge the City Council to clear the drains before the first rains, and I appeal to residents and vendors to stop throwing litter into them. A clean-up day organised with schools and businesses would cost little and save a great deal.

Yours faithfully

[signature]
Concerned Engineer
Bulawayo

18 Circular letter

A **circular** is one letter sent to many readers (customers, parents, residents, members). It has no individual inside address; use a general salutation ("Dear Customer", "Dear Parent") and close "Yours faithfully". It must be complete and easy to scan.

EXAMPLE 19 · CIRCULAR TO RESIDENTS

Bulawayo City Council
Engineering Services Department
City Hall
Bulawayo

24 October 2026

Dear Resident

WATER SUPPLY INTERRUPTION: SUBURBS AND HILLSIDE, 3 NOVEMBER 2026

We wish to inform you that water supply to Suburbs and Hillside will be interrupted from 07:00 to 19:00 on Tuesday 3 November 2026.

The interruption is needed to connect a new 400 mm trunk main that will improve water pressure in both suburbs.

Residents are advised to store enough water for the day. A water bowser will be stationed at Hillside Shops from 10:00. Supply may be cloudy for a short time after it is restored; please run your taps until the water is clear.

We apologise for the inconvenience. For enquiries, please call 0292 000 888.

Yours faithfully

[signature]
Eng. L Nyathi
Director of Engineering Services

19 Informal (personal) letter

Written to a friend or relative. **Differences from a formal letter**: only **your address and date** (no inside address); salutation with a first name ("Dear Rumbi"); no subject heading; friendly, conversational tone;

contractions allowed; close "Yours", "Love", "Your friend", "Best wishes"; sign with first name only. Paragraphs still need a clear opening, body and close.

EXAMPLE 20 · INFORMAL LETTER: ADVICE TO A YOUNGER FRIEND

Room 14, Hostel B
NUST
Bulawayo

24 October 2026

Dear Rumbi

Thanks for your letter, and congratulations on your A Level results! I'm really happy you've been offered a place in engineering next year.

You asked what first year is like. Honestly, it's busy, but it's fun. The biggest surprise for me was how much communication matters. We've had to give presentations, write memos and reports, and even sit an exam on communication skills. My advice is to keep your notes neat from day one, join a study group early and never miss practicals, because they make the theory easy to understand.

I'll be home in December, so let's meet and I'll show you my drawing board and the notes our group put together.

Say hello to everyone at home.

Your friend

Tinashe

20 Memo, formal email and public notice

EXAMPLE 21A · MEMO (REQUEST)

NUST · DEPARTMENT OF CIVIL AND WATER ENGINEERING
MEMORANDUM

TO: Chairperson
FROM: Class Representative, Part 1
DATE: 24 October 2026
SUBJECT: **EXTENDED LIBRARY HOURS DURING EXAMINATIONS**

1. The Part 1 class requests that the engineering library remain open until 22:00 from 26 October to 13 November 2026.

2. The library currently closes at 18:00, while most students have lectures until 17:00, leaving one hour for revision with reference books.

3. Forty-two students signed the attached request. Two class members have offered to help library staff with supervision.

4. Kindly advise by Wednesday 28 October 2026 whether the request can be granted.

TKM
Enc: signed request

Memo: no salutation, no close, numbered paragraphs, initials. Internal only.

EXAMPLE 21B · FORMAL EMAIL

To: resident.engineer@example.co.zw
Cc: site.agent@example.co.zw
Subject: Concrete pour for Bridge Deck B2 – request for inspection, Thu 29 Oct

Dear Eng. Mutasa

The reinforcement and formwork for Bridge Deck B2 will be complete by 16:00 on Wednesday 28 October 2026. Please could you inspect them before we pour concrete at 07:00 on Thursday 29 October?

The bar bending schedule and the cover-block check sheet are attached. I will be on site from 15:00 on Wednesday if you would like to inspect then.

Kind regards

Tafadzwa Moyo
Site Engineer, Zambezi Roads and Bridges
0771 000 333

Email rules: specific subject line; greeting and sign-off; short paragraphs; one topic per email; check attachments and recipients; no capitals (shouting) or emojis; reply within 24 hours.

EXAMPLE 21C · PUBLIC NOTICE

NOTICE

ROAD CLOSURE: GWANDA ROAD BRIDGE

Members of the public are advised that the Gwanda Road bridge over the Umzingwane River will be **CLOSED TO ALL TRAFFIC** from **06:00 on Saturday 7 November** to **18:00 on Sunday 8 November 2026** for bearing replacement.

Diversion: use the Esigodini road. Pedestrians may cross under escort.
We apologise for the inconvenience.

Eng. L Nyathi, Director of Engineering Services · 24 October 2026 · Enquiries: 0292 000 888

A notice answers **what, when, where, who, action required**, in large clear headings; it is signed and dated by the issuing authority.

21 Notice of meeting with agenda; press release

EXAMPLE 22A · NOTICE AND AGENDA

NUST ENGINEERING SOCIETY
NOTICE OF THE ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING

Notice is hereby given that the Annual General Meeting of the NUST Engineering Society will be held in Lecture Theatre 2 on Thursday 12 November 2026 at 14:00.

AGENDA

1. Opening and welcome
2. Apologies for absence
3. Minutes of the 2025 AGM
4. Matters arising
5. Chairperson's annual report
6. Treasurer's report and audited accounts
7. Amendment of the constitution (Article 6)
8. Election of office bearers for 2027
9. Any other business
10. Close

Nominations for office must reach the Secretary by 5 November 2026.

T Macheke (Miss), Secretary · 24 October 2026

EXAMPLE 22B · PRESS RELEASE

FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE · 24 October 2026

NUST STUDENTS LAUNCH FREE ONLINE STUDY BOARD

BULAWAYO – First-year Civil and Water Engineering students at the National University of Science and Technology have launched a free online study board that gives their class solved past papers, notes and a discussion forum on their phones.

The board, built by Group 13, works offline once installed and already covers three first-semester courses. "We wanted every student to have the same revision material, whatever their data budget," said class representative Tinashe Ndlovu.

The group plans to add second-semester courses in 2027.

ENDS

Media contact: T Ndlovu, 0771 000 444

Press release: headline; dateline (place); the most important facts first (who, what, when, where, why); a quotation; "ENDS"; contact details. Third person, factual.

22 Summary table and exam drill

Document	Order	Must include	Salutation / close
Enquiry	Direct	Who you are, specific numbered questions, deadline	Sir/Madam · faithfully
Reply / quotation	Direct	Reference to their letter, answer every question, prices, how to order	Named · sincerely
Order	Direct	Exact items, quantities, prices, total, delivery date/place, payment	Named · sincerely
Complaint	Direct	Facts, fault, effect, fix with deadline, evidence enclosed	Either
Adjustment	Direct	Apology and remedy first, brief explanation, prevention, goodwill	Named · sincerely

Document	Order	Must include	Salutation / close
Refusal	Indirect	Buffer, reasons, refusal, alternative, friendly close	Named · sincerely
Application / motivation	Persuasive	Post and source, matched qualifications, evidence, why them, interview request	Either
Acceptance / resignation	Direct	Decision first, dates, thanks, handover or reporting details	Named · sincerely
Circular	Direct	What, when, why, what readers must do, contact	Dear Resident · faithfully
Memo	Direct	TO/FROM/DATE/SUBJECT, numbered paragraphs, action and deadline, initials	None
Informal	Natural	Your address and date only, first name, friendly tone	Dear Rumbi · Your friend

EXAM DRILL · WRITE THESE UNDER TIME (ABOUT 30 MINUTES EACH)

1. Write to a hardware supplier enquiring about the price and delivery of 200 bags of cement and 5 tonnes of Y12 reinforcing bars. [20]
2. As the supplier, reply to the enquiry in Q1 with a quotation. [20]
3. Your hostel has had no hot water for two weeks. Write a letter of complaint to the Director of Accommodation. [20]
4. As the Director of Accommodation, reply to the complaint in Q3, granting the request. [20]
5. A school asks your firm to sponsor its prize-giving day. Write a letter refusing the request politely and offering an alternative. [20]
6. Write a letter of application for the post of Laboratory Technician advertised in a national newspaper. [20]
7. Write a motivation letter for a scholarship to study engineering. [20]
8. Write a letter requesting industrial attachment from a construction company. [20]
9. Prepare your curriculum vitae to accompany the letter in Q8. [20]
10. Write a letter accepting an offer of employment. [10] Write a letter resigning from your current post. [10]
11. Write a letter inviting a professional engineer to address your class. [15]
12. Write to the editor of a newspaper about the dangers of illegal sand mining near rivers. [20]
13. As the town engineer, write a circular to residents about a planned power or water interruption. [15]
14. Write a memo to all site staff announcing new PPE rules. [10] Write the same message as an email. [10]
15. Write a notice and agenda for the AGM of your club, and a press release announcing the new committee. [20]

BEFORE YOU HAND IN ANY LETTER, CHECK

☐ Both addresses (or memo heading) ☐ Date in full ☐ Salutation matches the close ☐ Subject heading ☐ Purpose in the first paragraph ☐ Every point in the question covered ☐ Action and deadline in the last paragraph ☐ Signature, name, designation ☐ Enclosures if mentioned ☐ No contractions or slang ☐ Spelling of names checked.

Sources used in this whitepaper

Bovee, C.L. and Thill, J.V. (2021) *Business Communication Today*. 15th edn. Harlow: Pearson.

Guffey, M.E. and Loewy, D. (2022) *Essentials of Business Communication*. 11th edn. Boston: Cengage.

Taylor, S. (2005) *Communication for Business: A Practical Approach*. 4th edn. Harlow: Pearson.

Ashley, A. (2003) *Oxford Handbook of Commercial Correspondence*. New edn. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

TCW 1103 class presentations (2026) on the complaint letter, the motivation letter, the memo and job applications.